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NOAA FISHERIES

Diving into Creatures of the Deep

March 24, 2025

Dive in and learn about creatures of the deep. These mysterious species live way below the surface of the ocean.



Gelatinous sea creature photographed using the ROV Deep Discoverer in 2015. Credit: NOAA Office of Ocean Exploration and Research

Ever wonder what lurks beneath the surface? One million species live in the sea—but we've only discovered about one-third of them, because they live in deep parts of the ocean that

are hard to explore. Many of them have been seen only a handful of times! Join us this week as we dive into creatures that live in the deep ocean—from corals, to jellyfish, to octopus, and more. Discover how they survive in these cold, dark habitats and the tools and technology we use to learn more about these animals.

Deep-Sea Creature Features

New Study Sheds Light on Alaska's Largest, Most Mysterious Shark

Researchers created a "one-stop shop" for information critical to conserving the highly vulnerable Pacific sleeper shark.

Read about this vulnerable predator >



Pacific sleeper shark photographed at 3,125 feet depth by the remotely operated vehicle, Deep Discoverer. Credit: NOAA Office of Ocean Exploration and Research

Critters of the Twilight Zone

A look at the dark and lovely critters of the mesopelagic zone, or ocean twilight zone, caught during the fall Bottom Trawl Survey aboard NOAA Ship *Henry B. Bigelow*. This at-sea blog was written by biological science technician Katie Rogers.

Take a look at some of the amazing critters found 200–1,000 meters deep >



A profile perspective of a red fish with a large eye, pairs of leg-like appendages, and armor plate-like scales lying on a white table. Credit: NOAA Fisheries/Katie Rogers

Researchers Find Massive Rare Sponge Mounds Hiding in the Deep Sea

NOAA scientists and collaborators have found rare deep-sea sponge mounds between two of California's most explored marine protected areas, signifying how vast and mysterious our ocean truly is.

Scientists were surprised to find this vast mound in an unexpected place >



This living glass sponge was spotted during a 2018 cruise. This photo reveals the bright colors and textures commonly associated with the living sponge, which is usually found in small patches. Credit: NOAA Fisheries, Marine Applied Research and Exploration

11 Strange But True Facts About Lancetfish

The lancetfish is one of the stranger fish found in Alaskan marine waters. Here are some interesting facts about this unusual fish.

Find out why lancetfish really are creatures from the Twilight Zone! >

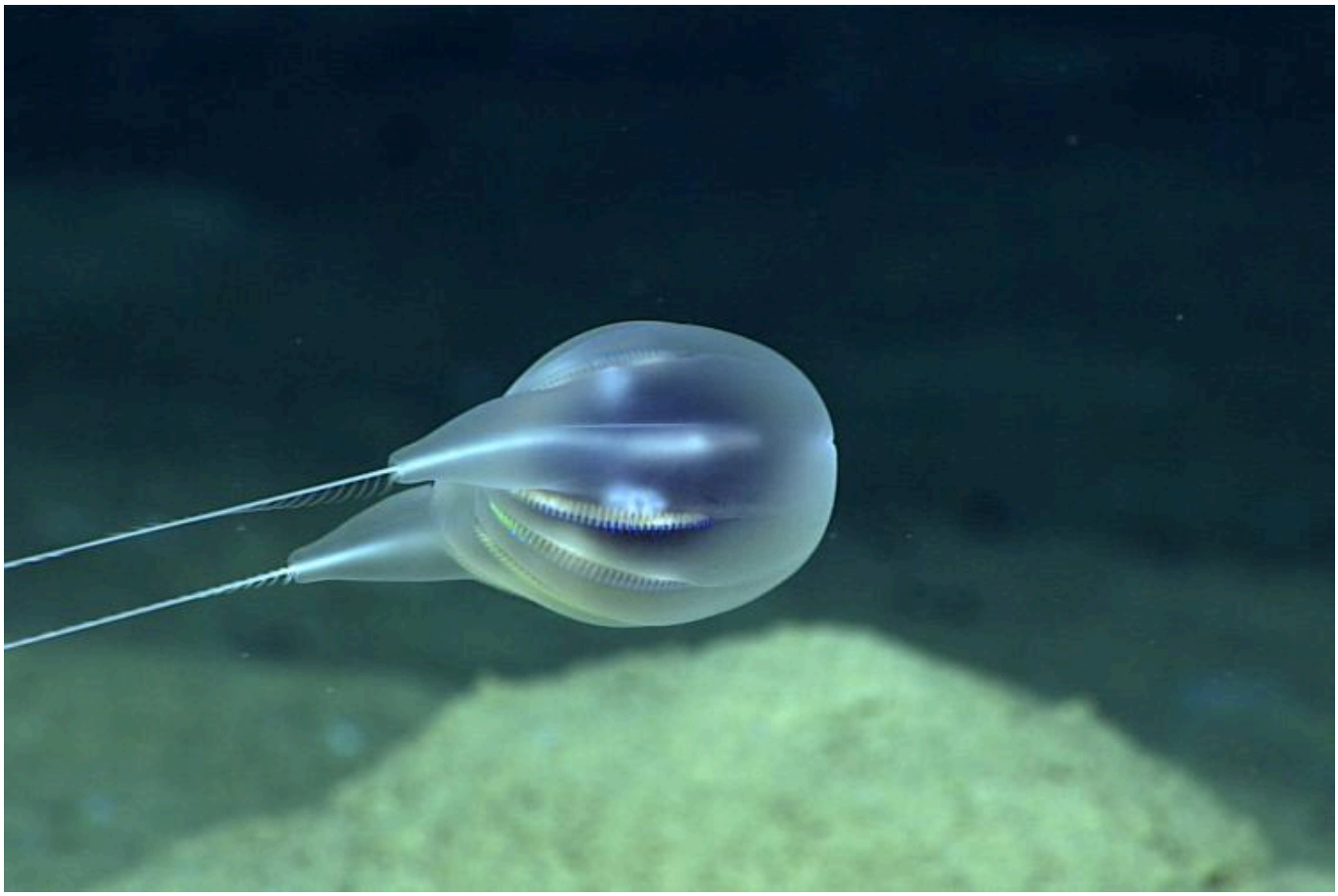


A lancetfish on a wooden surface. Credit: NOAA

NOAA Scientists Virtually Discover New Species of Comb Jelly Near Puerto Rico

The comb jellies were recorded two and a half miles below sea level using NOAA's Deep Discoverer remotely operated vehicle.

Scientists identified the new species using only high-definition video ›

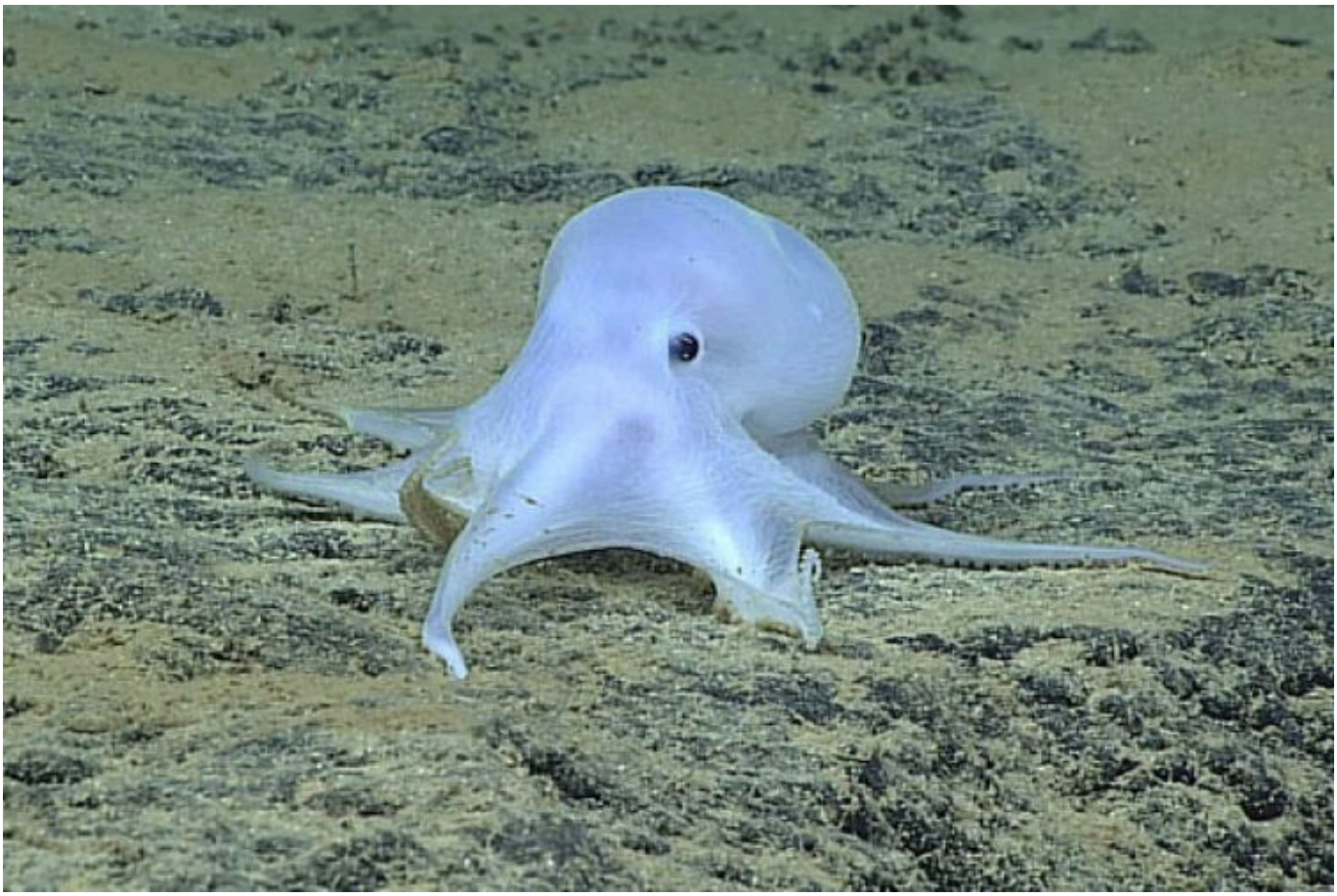


An image of the newly discovered ctenophore taken by the Deep Discoverer remotely operated vehicle. Credit: NOAA Office of Ocean Exploration and Research

Ghostly Octopod Highlights How Little We Know About Life on Earth

In this interview, NOAA Fisheries zoologist Mike Vecchione says that of all the space on Earth that contains multicellular life, more than 95 percent of that is in the deep sea. And we know almost nothing about it.

What this discovery at almost 4,300 meters depth tells us about our knowledge of the ocean ›

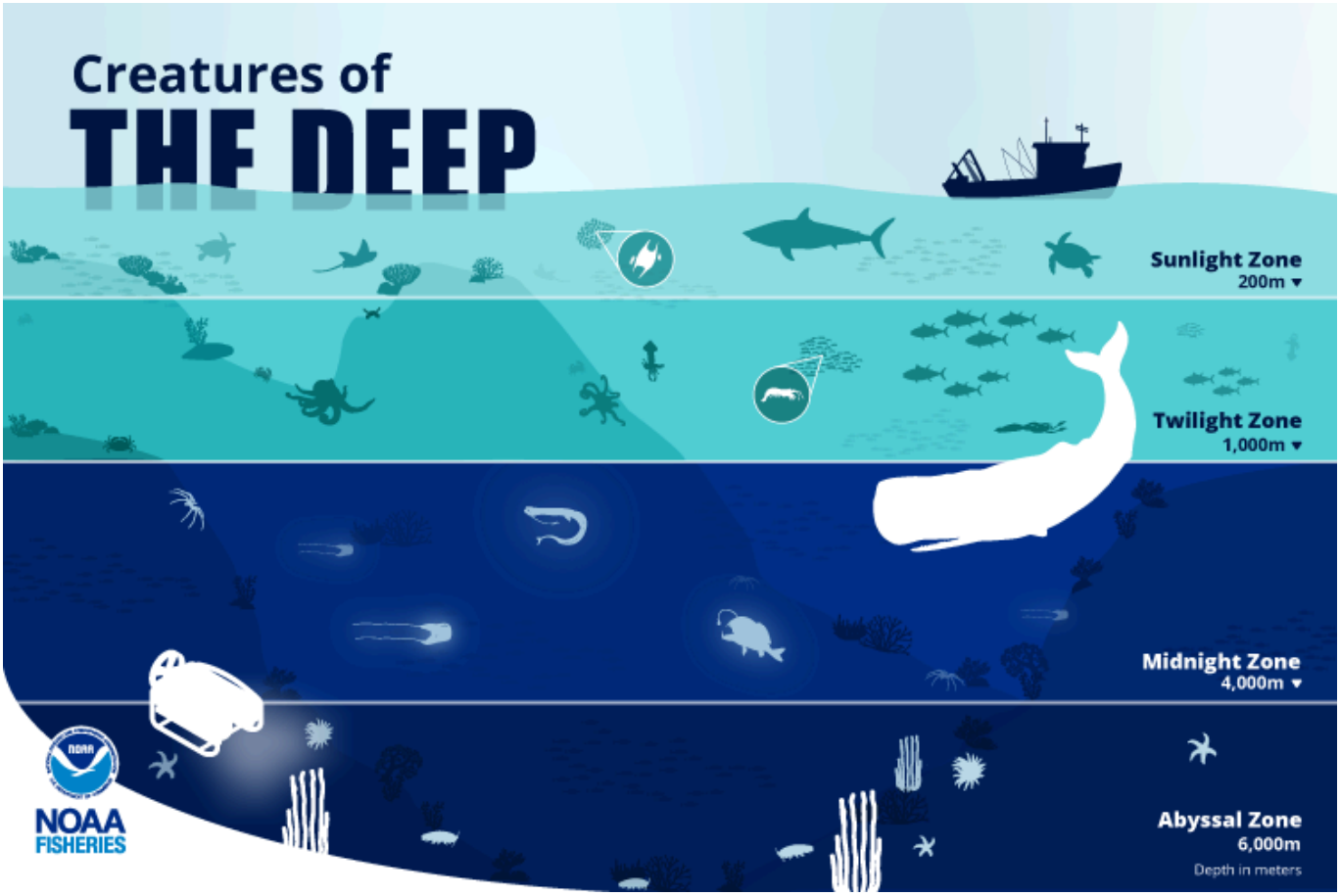


This ghostlike octopod is almost certainly an undescribed species and may not belong to any described genus. Credit: NOAA Office of Ocean Exploration and Research

Multimedia

Infographic—Creatures of the Deep

Take a look at the creatures that live in each zone of the ocean, from the warm and productive sunlight zone to the deep and chilly abyssal zone.



An infographic depicting what sea life lives in each ocean zone. Credit: NOAA Fisheries

Video—Lancetfish: Unlocking the Secrets of the Deep

Scientists are using lancetfish's unusual stomachs, which contain barely digested food items, to learn more about the creatures that make up the middle of the marine food web and about the pervasiveness of plastics in the ocean.

Video—Windows to the Deep 2021

NOAA Fisheries marine biologist Allen Collins is co-leading the Windows to the Deep 2021 expedition. Learn about the fascinating species, habitat—even a shipwreck—they might see as they explore the ocean with an underwater remotely-operated vehicle.

Video—Windows to the Deep 2021: A Firsthand Account

NOAA Fisheries marine biologist Allen Collins has just returned from co-leading the Windows to the Deep 2021 expedition. Learn about the fascinating species and habitat they saw as they explored the ocean with an underwater remotely-operated vehicle.

Video—Combing the Deep: NOAA's Discovery of a New Ctenophore

On an underwater expedition off the coast of Puerto Rico in 2015, led by the NOAA Office of Ocean Exploration and Research, scientists discovered a new species of comb jelly. It is the first species solely identified through high-definition video.

Video—Habitat Exploration: Deep-Sea Corals

There are more than 70 underwater canyons off the northeastern coast of the United States, some more than 3 miles deep. In this video, journey to the deep and discover new species of deep-sea coral and more through the eye of a remotely operated vehicle.

Understanding the Giant Pacific Octopus

There are about 300 octopus species in the world, but only seven or eight are found in Alaska. Watch as our scientists learn more about the largest octopus species in the world: the giant Pacific octopus.

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